You could see the sun shifting off our patch as soon as they knew they'd had what they came for. At first, they held off on this, because they realised it would be in their interest to have the cables, but it was evident to me. As Orwell would have understood all too well, these things appear in the language. The *Guardian*, along with the *New York Times*, increasingly wanted to characterise me as a hacker, as an unstable source, but in this they were only revealing their own anxiety. You should always be careful of questioning people's motives: you only reveal your own. And this slow deracination of me and of WikiLeaks was merely a way for these organisations both to protect themselves against prosecution and claim more credit. Children behave with more grace under pressure, and although I must often have been high-handed in my protectiveness and in my steering of this project, it could possibly be considered part of their job to understand why. Instead, they went to war with me and totally forgot what the opposition was.

There was a very personal element, too. The special investigations reporter and I had got on well when it was just us. In Brussels and Stockholm, and initially in London, we were friends, and he made me feel that I was some younger version of himself. He sort of fell for my idealism, if you'll allow the possibility, and before I knew it he was behaving erratically and needily, like a besotted person, claiming he had done the most work and everything was his idea. To use some of those mixed metaphors the *Guardian* is so fond of, he wanted to be the star who brought home the big fish. It was somehow a matter of honour for this man with his colleagues. I didn't particularly care who got the gong, but the twelve angry men were not looking at the evidence. They were looking to themselves, their positions, their late careers, and while this is all very human, it got in the way of our work.

The real test of journalistic mettle comes with the counterattack. You always know it's coming. People wanted to drink champagne the night of the big leak, but I was thinking, 'Hold the corks. The White House and the Pentagon are coming back at us and it won't be nice.' Their first move was to say the material was insignificant. 'There is not a lot new here for those who have been following developments closely,' said the first (unnamed) government rent-a-quote on the *Washington Post*'s speed dial. That's standard. And the next wave, led by Rupert Murdoch's rival British daily *The Times*, suggested that the material we had published had already led to